



Pager Rotation Duties in DevOps

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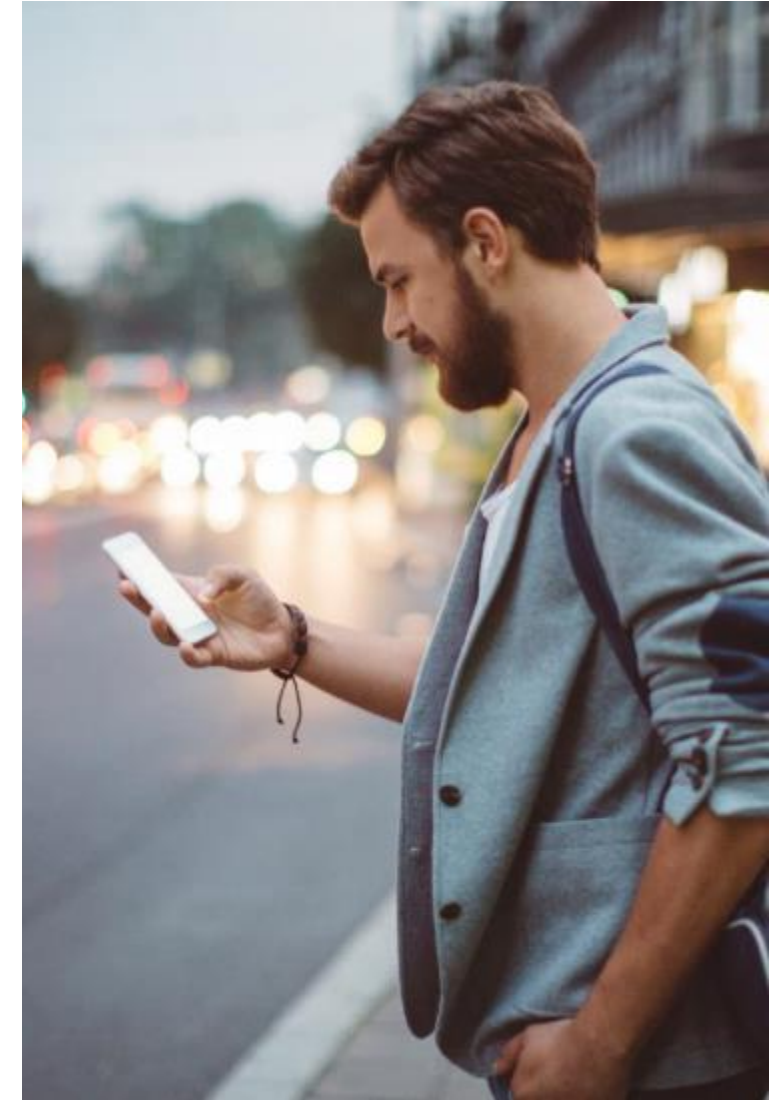
Why do we need a Pager Rotation?

Production systems require 24/7 support

Rapid incident response minimizes costly downtime

Active pager rotation improves overall service reliability

Incidents provide critical operational feedback for continuous development



How the Pager Rotation Works

Automated Incident Escalation
Workflows

There will be a scheduled primary and secondary on-call. Developers will share the on-call duties with the Operations teams. The escalation procedures will be clearly defined and, in most cases, automated.



Step 1

Alert Triggered



Step 2

Primary on-call paged



Step 3

No response in timely manor, backup on-call is paged



Step 4:

Incident Resolved/Restored

Pager Rotation Process



Noisy Alerts (Bad)

Alert Behavior

Non-actionable and noisy alerts that trigger too often and wake people up for non-critical errors.

Operational Impact

Leads directly to developer fatigue, missed pages, and ignored alerts.



Meaningful Alerts (Good)

Alert Behavior

Highly actionable and urgent alerts that focus purely on client-facing downtime or customer impacting incidents.

Operational Impact

Develops trust in the operational paging system for critical alerts.

- Implement Fair Rotations
 - Schedules should be equal and predictable to support a healthy work-life balance. (Atlassian)
- Runbooks and Ownership
 - Maintain a clear system ownership boundary and keep detailed incident runbooks (Atlassian/DevOps/Medium)
- Automation and Incident Reviews
 - Prioritize automated remediation (Google SRE)
 - Conduct blameless postmortems (Atlassian)





Developers Owning Production



“We found that when we woke up developers at 2 AM, defects were fixed faster than ever.” - Patrick Lightbody, SVP of Product Management at New Relic.

Traditional Operations vs DevOps

Traditional Operations

- Operations teams own incidents exclusively
- On-call relies heavily on physical pager
- Adopts a purely reactive response
- Relies on manual escalation pathways
- Single goal mindset to restore service at all costs

DevOps Model

- Shared operational ownership across Dev & Ops teams
- Utilizes automated mobile alerting platforms
- Prioritizes continuous architectural feedback
- Relies on automated escalation pathways
- Double goal mindset to restore service and improve system resilience

Key Takeaways



Pager Rotation

Essential for maintaining systems requiring high-reliability

Incident Automation

Reduced engineer burnout with filtered and actionable alerts

Shared Ownership

Directly improves software quality

Lessons Learned

Continuous reviews of outages to improve the DevOps team

Resources:

- The DevOps Handbook (2nd Edition) – Chapter 16
- DevOps. (March 6, 2026). [On-Call Rotation Best Practices: Reducing Burnout and Improving Response](#)
- Google. (n.d.). [Chapter 8 - On-Call](#)
- PagerDuty. (n.d.) [On-Call Rotations and Schedules](#)
- OnPage. (April 21, 2026). [DevOps – Roles and Responsibilities](#)
- Atlassian. (n.d.). [A manager's guide to improving on-call](#)
- Alertops. (July 12, 2019). [Best Practices for Managing On-Call Rotation \(in 2025\)](#)
- Medium. (Feb 27, 2025). [On-Call Rotation: A Complete Guide to Best Practices](#)

